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David Finck

David Finck was born in Rochester, New York on August 26, 1958. His versatility as a bassist has enabled him to perform and record with artists from every musical genre. David can also be found working as a producer and leader of his own quartet. The group's first recording, on Soundbrush Records is entitled "Future Day/The David Finck Quartet."

David was interviewed in Utica, New York on May 29, 2015 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Utica, New York. I'm pleased to have musician David Finck with me. And congratulations on playing the best instrument.

DF: Well I don't know about that. It doesn't feel like that all the time. But it's been mine for years now.

MR: I just am enamored of the bass and its role in music, you know, not only jazz but jazz especially. Do you have a philosophy about your role as a bassist?

DF: I do have a philosophy about my role as a bassist. My primary concern — should I be looking at you or the camera?

MR: You can look at me.

DF: My primary — you edit this I assume.

MR: We'll see. It depends on what you say.

DF: As a bassist in a jazz group, or frankly as a bassist in any group, there is a lot of function in your job description. You have to function rhythmically and you have to function harmonically. And I've discovered after all these years and after having listened to hundreds of other bassists, that there are limited numbers of ways of effectively guiding a band through the harmony of the song and the bass lines that we construct in the moment have to function to help shape the harmony. In other words, if we've all agreed that we're going to play "Happy Birthday" in the key of F, and the pianist or guitarist or another harmonic instrument, although it's not required, once we agree on the chord changes, that I have to function in a way in which I create the bottom of that harmony, which is the bass, the foundation for it. And that in working my way to the next chord in a song, I have to effectively guide everybody so they know where we're going. The pianist has to do it too, but I can do it without the pianist, and he can do it without me (he or she). So my philosophy is basically one of rhythm and I guess you would call it basic voice leading, which comes from Bach essentially. Those little Bach chorales that we had to learn in music school, those bass lines are unbelievable. And when I listen to my favorite bass players, whether they know it or not, that's what they're doing. So I'm particularly

fond of Ron Carter's bass lines. When Ron Carter walks a bass line I can often hear the implied harmony between the major resting places in a song. It's like, oh yeah that would be a diminished chord and that would be a dominant chord, and that gets me to the next place. It's all in there. Paul Chambers also.

MR: It's a big responsibility.

DF: It is.

MR: Because you can mess up two things at once, right?

DF: Yes. Well we all can. I'm good at messing up all kinds of things. But yes, you know, really good bass players in many ways drive a band more than a drummer in many ways.

MR: I concur. Because you think of some of the famous trios with guitar, piano and bass — hardly any with piano, drums and reed instrument or something like that. I mean the bass is more to be missed when it's not there.

DF: I would agree, and that keeps us employed.

MR: Yeah. And especially if you play the stand-up. What happens as a bassist when someone calls a tune that you don't know?

DF: After I've gotten over my initial panic I always confess I don't know that song — or I say, "I haven't played that song in a long time" which is often the case. And I might ask the pianist if he knows it, to just quickly jump through the chords, or if it's simple enough he'll go, "all right the first part is in F, starts on the one chord, the bridge starts on the two chord." Unless it's really challenging I can usually find my way through it. The more songs you know the more you realize that is the same chords as the bridge to that. And at some point sometimes you even mess that up. You go it's this — wait, wait, wait, wait, we're playing this not that. So being honest when you don't know it I think is a very good thing to do because people are relying on you. It's like saying, "hey man go fly that 747." "Hey I've only flown a Cessna." You know?

MR: And there's always other songs that could be called. So why —

DF: Yes. And I always ask guys if they have something unusual, bring it. I want to know what chords you're going to play, especially if you reharmonize the standard. I want to know. I don't want to be the guy going, "eww really?" To what end?

MR: I was reading and a word popped out that's been written about you is ubiquitous. Like you're all over the place I guess. And I wondered if you made a conscious career choice between classical and jazz. Could you have gone either way?

DF: Well I would say that I started out as a classical bass student at the Eastman School of Music, which is a pretty well-known conservatory. I was good enough to get in. I think they only took four or five of us at a time. Now when I look at the guys, my friends who play in the Metropolitan Opera Orchestra or the New York Philharmonic, I say to myself there's no way. I could never play that Wagner tone poem. No way. Because I realize

now that I have spent most of my career playing popular music. And it's a different skill set and it's another art form. Even though the bass lines function much in the same way. Beethoven's bass lines are fantastic. And the voice leading is unbelievable. Mozart — it's the same thing. But you have to spend a lot of time practicing with the bow and learning those parts that are near impossible for me. Those guys breeze through it like it's a blues. So I don't know that it was a conscious effort, but I kind of just started getting involved in jazz and popular music. And I enjoy all kinds of music. I have occasionally been called to play something with a symphony. "Hey can you play in the bass section, we're doing 'Beethoven's Ninth.'" And I always say, honestly again, there's probably ten other guys you might want to call first but I'd love to do it. You know one of my friends says, "come on just do it." And I usually stand at the end of the bass section and have a great time and it's always educational. Because those guys that really know "Beethoven's Ninth" and have been playing it for 40 years, I mean there's a lot of information coming out of those instruments. So with pop music I found myself getting called for certain things. I do play electric bass as well, although it's not my primary instrument. And I know my limitations on that instrument as well. So as an acoustic bassist I've gotten a chance to record a lot of pop music, people like Rod Stewart and George Michael and Linda Ronstadt and others like that.

MR: Yeah I was looking at your discography on your website and I think it was between 1997 and 2008, I actually counted on the screen. It was hard. It was like 125 records there. And I'm sure you've done a few since 2008.

DF: I have.

MR: So why do you get those calls — in your mind?

DF: Well it depended on the music and the producer. First of all I show up on time. There's a lot of money at stake when somebody's making a record. Like those "Rod Stewart Sings Standards" records. They spent a fortune. You can't come walking in even five minutes late to a session. So you need a good reputation in that department. I was fortunate enough to do a lot of worker for a producer named Phil Ramone, and Phil called me for a lot of things. And I think part of it is because I take direction, I keep my mouth shut unless I'm asked to make a contribution. Because there's a lot of egos flying around the room in a recording session. I try to play in tune. There's no such thing as perfect intonation and I'm certainly not in the running for that, but I try to be very careful about it. And that's part of my function also, being in tune with the piano because I know there are going to be layers of sounds over me. I think I'm good at playing with a click and still having it swing.

MR: Ooh that's important, yeah.

DF: Yeah. And on a lot of them I stayed under the radar. I've seen explosive situations in recording studios and I always managed to just — if it was going south and I wasn't being asked to help, I let the people in charge do their job. People get really upset, and I've seen it happen. "Hey you know we should play sticks instead of brushes at the bridge." And I've seen a producer go, "Who asked you to tell the drummer" this or that.

MR: So like the piano player or maybe someone might say that, and like, "Who asked you?"

DF: Yeah. I mean there's a way to make that contribution. If you really feel it you could say, "hey I have a thought." But I found that for the most part a good producer, or often times an arranger with a clear vision, if he's really good it's displayed for you. It's written on the chart. Or he'll say, "David, walk on the bridge. I was wrong. Don't play it in two, go into four." Those kind of things. I hate it when I go into the studio and nobody knows what they're doing. Do you want your brain surgeon not to know what he's doing? I mean come on.

MR: Let's take the Rod Stewart thing for an example. Was he singing while the rhythm section was playing?

DF: He was on one or two sessions that we did in Los Angeles. For the most part no. Someone else tracked his vocals for him.

MR: Oh someone else sings so that you have a reference point or something?

DF: Yeah we have a reference and I don't know whether he even knew some of these songs so he could learn them from somebody else. I probably shouldn't be saying that on camera. But he was not there for most of them. And this is not uncommon. I did an entire record with Gladys Knight without Gladys Knight, with a really wonderful singer who tracked for her named Vaneese Thomas.

MR: What's her name?

DF: Vaneese Thomas. And Vaneese is the daughter of Rufus Thomas, "Funky Chicken."

MR: Yeah.

DF: She's a great singer and she tracked a bunch of standards and we played with her. And then I guess Gladys — well Gladys, I don't know where she lives. I don't think she lives in New York. She might have put the parts on in Los Angeles.

MR: Yeah. You know it is interesting when you're doing a record for a singer, I've done some studio work, and if no one is singing, especially from a piano player, like you're thinking maybe I shouldn't be playing here. What am I covering up potentially. And that's a weird feeling.

DF: It is a weird feeling. Along with what you experienced, it affects the overall flow of a song. I happen to know a lot of songs, I love songs and songwriters and so often times I know the tune and kind of have an idea of what the lyric might be at a certain point. But it's actually — it's not an ideal way to make a record with anybody, if you're really

making music in the human way. You know music is made very differently now for the most part. You extract a rhythm track from Marvin Gaye, as we know from hearing about the Pharrell — Robin Thicke stuff and they extract this idea from that one, and often times they are fragments of files, sound files, that are actually lifted. I can't tell you how many times I've heard a James Brown drum part, or even James Brown making a sound inserted into somebody's song. And the result is like yeah, some of it feels great and some of it's fun and everything, but it's not the same as playing music live with someone else. And sadly we have a generation or maybe two now of listeners who have no idea. My children, who have heard a lot of music and come to my jobs and concerts and travel, you know when they turn on the radio and they sing along with these songs I say to myself that's not a song, or that guy's not singing, he's really yelling at me. You know. And I say hey man, if you're going to sing, sing. Don't talk. Sing. And certainly don't yell. I don't need to be yelled at.

MR: Oh you sound just like me.

DF: I mean I know it's old school. But the truth of the matter is that these people have made the mistake of not learning from what came before. And with the advent of the technology that we have those people don't know anything about songs. They don't know what makes a Stevie Wonder song a great song, let alone an Irving Berlin song or Cole Porter or Stephen Foster for that matter. They've learned to stick stuff together over a drum beat. And I'll be the first to say I love the way some of those things feel because they're funky. But for me, I could put on an Earth, Wind & Fire record that was recorded in the 70s and go that's just as funky as this rap artist is. And it's got a good melody and a great arrangement and it's human and they're not yelling. Philip Bailey is singing. And that means something. Hopefully it will come back. I don't know.

MR: Yeah. And it's funny from a bass player standpoint too, that that part of music has become so predominant. You know, when a car goes by you and you hear the [scats] I sometimes wonder well what does a bass player think of that. Are they happy about that?

DF: That bass line functions in that piece most of the time. I mean usually there's a drum loop and there's a bass line that works, and I don't really like it because most of them aren't really inventive or creative in any way. And most of the time it's not even a bass player. The bass player Marcus Miller is a fantastic electric bass player. And actually he plays acoustic bass also, which is a little frightening for me, because he's something else. He has played classic bass lines on songs where I go that is inventive. How did he think of that? Like he's a wonderful musician. Also Anthony Jackson is a favorite of mine. But the stuff that's made with loops and on the computer and glued together, I just don't consider it songwriting at its best, and I don't consider it music-making at its best. I'm not saying it's invalid, it's just not to my taste.

MR: Well that reminds me of when my father would come into the room when I was playing The Beatles and he'd go, "what's wrong with your record player?" Some things never change.

DF: Well that's interesting. I mean I think that, I mean my parents, interestingly enough, they liked The Beatles. My parents recognized good songs. So it didn't bother them. They thought The Beatles were cute. You know because we were going nuts. I think that your argument has to be well defended. And if you can specifically say here's what I don't like about this and here's what I do like about that. I mean of the rap artists I like Snoop Dog. I think he's got a groove, he swings, he's humorous. I don't like — I'm not going to mention the guys that I don't like but I feel like they're yelling and their ideas are violent or misogynistic or, it just doesn't appeal to me. I understand it's a reflection of society dot dot dot. You know, don't expect it to sound like Jerome Kern. But I don't think it's great songwriting or music-making.

MR: Well you have a solo record out now, correct?

DF: Yes.

MR: Were you able to record that as an ensemble?

DF: I did record most of it as an ensemble. There were a couple of guys that weren't — Bob Sheppard lives in Los Angeles and I said I just need two short solos so I did that high tech, with e-mail.

MR: Did you actually do it — he didn't come?

DF: He didn't come. I sent him the file and he played to the rhythm section. But he knows how to play to a rhythm section, as does Jeremy Pelt was the trumpet player. I was actually there for Jeremy's part. He couldn't make my session so he came in later. And you know, that might be cheating a little bit according to my philosophy about music, but I also like the way he reacted to what was on the track. And he did it in a pass or two, so I didn't feel like he dissected everything and worked everything out.

MR: Right or that he laid down seven solos and you took bar one from this and that.

DF: We didn't do that.

MR: Now when you do your own — was that an investment on your part to do your own CD, or did you have a record label?

DF: A record label.

MR: Okay. That's good. A lot of projects the artists pay for them themselves.

DF: Yeah they do. Again, unfortunately, between piracy and the ease with which we can exchange music files, record companies have lost a lot. Not that there's any love between me and record companies because I've watched them over the years make a mess of a lot of things. But they've lost a lot. And that's why they're all doing these — they call them "360 deals." They want to make a record, produce it, then they want to manage you and

they want to sell you tee shirts, and they want to be your agent. So in that case they're not signing too many jazz musicians.

MR: I see.

DF: But I can tell you, I've been involved with the union pretty heavily in the last 15, 20 years. And I've gone to some of their negotiations with the record company, I guess the management, because they have collective bargaining agreements between the record companies and the musicians union. And I saw graphs of charts of how the money is divided. Record company, distributor, truck driver who schleps the CDs around, and the musicians were at the bottom. And I remember the president of our union saying, "I could multiply that by 20 and you still wouldn't see it." And I sat there and I said to myself we're the ones making the product. It should be the exact opposite. But that's sort of what everything I guess has dissolved into that at this point.

MR: When you play on a record like Rod Stewart, that sold a lot of records, that was like a platinum.

DF: Yeah, multi-platinum.

MR: Do you get paid more for a successful record like that than you do from playing for some other jazz artist who's not going to sell a tenth of —

DF: Like a Mark Murphy record you mean?

MR: Yeah.

DF: Musicians get paid for their work at the session, essentially an hourly system. It's a scale. Then there is a special payments fund. And that is where we get some type of a royalty. And it's not based on the success of the record. That fund is funded by successful records.

MR: Right. This is an ASCAP thing?

DF: No, no. Jeez I think it's called secondary markets fund or something. But you get, like if you've done a hundred record sessions in a year you'll get a check that reflects that. And then if the song gets put in a movie or on a T.V. show or in a video game, which is common now, it's been registered and in theory you'll get some extra payment for that, as opposed to getting your five dollars for doing a record and then good-bye. So I've always been strongly in favor of the union because it protects us and it allows us to have a little bit of something, back end, down the line. And my record or someone's small record doesn't generate enough money to contribute to that fund. But the Rod Stewart records did, and the J Lo records or whatever. And by J Lo I don't mean Joe Lovano.

MR: No, I knew you did not.

DF: But anyway, you do make a little bit extra.

MR: Yeah. The Spotify and the whole thing is another delivery system now. Do you get surprised by checks you receive in the mail for things you did that you don't even remember.

DF: I don't think I've gotten a check from Spotify.

MR: Yeah. I kind of mixed my question there.

DF: Every now and then I'll get a check. There are, in fact, much to the credit of the current American Federation of Musicians administration and the administration at Local 802, I have gotten some checks from performance rights organizations in other parts of the world. And I know that they have made an effort to travel to Germany and make a deal. There's money there. There's always money there. So every now and then I go well it might not be a lot, it might just be 60 bucks or 80 bucks or whatever, but you go well okay, we're not lost.

MR: Right. Somehow the system is working. It's nice to know that.

DF: It works poorly and there's a lot of dishonesty in it. I think in the United States it's really bad, for a lot of different reasons. Education being part of it. For my kids, even though their dad is a musician, they grew up with, "hey check out this song," you know, e-mailing each other tunes and that's how it is.

MR: I bet that they knew what the word "gig" meant.

DF: My kids? Yeah.

MR: Long before — when they were quite young.

DF: Yeah.

MR: Is the life of a musician, and a busy one, is it hard to be a family man, whatever that might mean?

DF: Yes. I would say yes it is. It is stressful, mostly because of the travel and the hours. I missed a lot of events because I was in Japan or in Europe. Yeah it can be difficult. On the other hand, you know my girls came to Paris and my son came to London and they got to do some things that the average kid might not get to do and they've met famous people. Although they didn't even know who George Michael was, of course.

MR: I was going to say they've met people they didn't know were famous.

DF: Yeah. "Dad, who is this guy?" There was a stadium full of people screaming you know. I was like a rock star for a minute there.

MR: Interesting. I'm assuming you were playing the electric bass.

DF: No I was playing both.

MR: Okay.

DF: I had done a record with George in 1999 and he decided to do some of those songs so I got the call. The guy has unbelievable talent. A really great singer. Every night he knocked me out.

MR: What do you like to see from up-and-coming singers as far as taking care of their own business. I mean musical business.

DF: That's a good question. I like singers who are prepared, that have music for their songs, in their key, who know their tempos. Those are the basics from singers. I've worked with a lot of singers. I think I've worked with just about every singer I've ever wanted to with the exception of Frank Sinatra and James Taylor. But I worked with Jack Jones and I played for Peggy Lee and many, many others, Rosemary Clooney.

MR: And Joe Williams.

DF: Joe Williams. But singers, it always amazes me. Because they have the most potential to communicate the most stuff within a song. They've got the lyrics and they've got the melody and they have a chance to express those things. And it's not easy keeping that balance between words and music. But most of them just don't do it. Most of them, I find, listen to themselves sing and make themselves more important than the song. And that is a hard thing to get away from. I can understand how it happens. But I remember playing for Rosemary Clooney toward the end. She had nothing left. Nothing. I mean her voice was really going. And she sang [sings], "what'll I do when you are far" — and I said, you know what, that's my Aunt Rose singing right to me. She communicated all of the emotion of the song without the voice. Others are so busy showing you what they've got, their voice, that they completely lose sight of what the song is. I'll give one example, and I think she's a great singer, Christina Aguilera. She can really sing. But I saw her on T.V. sing "Have Yourself a Merry Little Christmas" and it was unrecognizable.

MR: Pyrotechnics.

DF: Yeah. [sings distorted notes]. And it's amazing. And I sat there and I said just sing the song. Can't you just sing the song? Otherwise write your own. Because it didn't make it more emotional, it didn't deliver anything more, it was just her being about her. And you know I get upset by this stuff because if it's a song I really like and somebody does that I'm like oh God, why are you doing that. Frank Sinatra, in my opinion, probably one of the greatest musicians I could think of, had a way of making the song present itself. I know he's been accused of changing words or some of his renditions aren't to my taste. But the bulk of his work is unsurpassed. And many times when he changed a word I think he had a good reason for doing that. Some words swing harder than others. If you say "the" it doesn't swing. "That" has punctuation at the end and if you place that in the right place it makes a difference. Granted Cole Porter may not have written the word "that," but I think Frank knew some stuff that a lot of people didn't know. And actually there's a very funny story because Cole Porter got upset with Frank changing some of the words and he sent Frank a letter saying if you can't sing my songs as I wrote them, please don't sing them. And Frank wrote back: if you don't like the royalty checks, send them back. I

think it worked out okay, but I can tell you this. I saw Frank sing two or three times. At Carnegie Hall I jumped out of my seat like it was The Beatles when he walked out on stage I was like, "Wow." It was exquisite. And then I heard him later at Radio City Music Hall and I was way in the back in the nosebleed seats, only ones I could afford, but he sang "One for my Baby" and it wasn't even that I felt like he was singing to me. I felt like I was sitting at the bar next to him. Like that's pretty amazing. Really a super talent that man was.

MR: That's a nice tribute you just gave him. I spent some time really analyzing the effect of "Fly Me To the Moon," the thing he did with Basie and the Quincy Jones arrangement. And I said my God, that's like a perfect piece of music. And at the end where he goes, "hot damn" I go where does that come from?

DF: I don't know. But it's funny, you know, when I was on the way here I was listening to "Witchcraft." It's a great arrangement. And I realized that one of the things about Sinatra that's so fantastic is he's in no hurry. If I sing along, I always get there before he does. Like you know what? He's relaxed. Joe Williams was like that too. No panic. Even when you're going fast. Right? Peggy Lee also. I remember playing with her and we played "Them There Eyes." And we were like [beats fast] maybe double time underneath her. Or maybe it was "What a Little Moonlight Can Do."

MR: Probably.

DF: I can't remember. And she just cruised along. And she was swinging. She wasn't like floating in space. She was in it with us, but it didn't feel like we were going 75 miles per hour. It really did not. It's kind of special, that stuff. A good horn player is like that too.

MR: Have you ever played with a singer or an instrumentalist who played so far behind the beat that you thought, "I'd better slow down?"

DF: Not that I better slow down, but that I better make sure it doesn't slow down. That the song doesn't slow down. Yeah there are some guys I play with who play behind the beat, and it can be annoying.

MR: Now is that true for drummers too? I've had people sort of debate about playing on top of the time, playing behind the time, and then some people say, "the time is the time." Like if you're on top of the time then you're rushing.

DF: Well I don't know that I agree with that statement. I think that there is a way where music leans forward and leans backward. And we're not machines. And even with a click track you can lean forward and it can be okay. And I always felt like there was some classic rhythm sections where the bass player might be a little ahead of the drummer, if you really put it up on a screen and analyzed it. And it feels unbelievable. And for whatever reason. I mean Ray Brown used to really drive hard with Oscar [Peterson] — they would rush but who cares? It was fantastic. So yeah, I don't think there's a rule about that. If

you listen to Basie's band, you know certain figures, they sit back. There's a great record of Peggy Lee singing Cy Coleman's "I've Got Your Number." And there are a couple of horn figures where you can just hear — the lead trumpet player must have said, "we're playing it like this." And they just play the figure just a little more relaxed than the rest of the band is. And it's great. I mean to me that's the music.

MR: Do you have any memories, when you were a kid, that you can think about now that you realized you had a sense of time and that you could feel grooves and feel the beat?

DF: Where I could feel the beat?

MR: Did you used to listen, for instance, to like the top 40 and get a sense of movement.

DF: Oh yeah, sure. You know there was top 40 music that appealed to me for whatever reason. I mean I always, I mean I don't know how old I was when I really got into how something felt. Is that what you're asking me?

MR: Yeah.

DF: Maybe I wasn't aware of it until I was 12 or 13 or 14, but I may have responded to it previously. And I think that pop music is good for that, definitely good for it. It's a lot easier to under [claps prominent beat] than it is to go [claps complicated rhythm]. That's a much more complicated and fluid and difficult thing to grab onto initially. And then when you digest it a little bit you realize wow that really does feel good the way they do that. But certain drummers stand out and you can hear it in their cymbal. But for young people I think, and I don't want to call it simple, but there is a simplicity to a bass drum/snare drum thing that's clear. And it's a good start.

MR: You can feel the backbeat.

DF: You can feel the backbeat. Jazz has a backbeat too, it's just that especially on the drums, you know in jazz you lead with the ride cymbal more than the bass drum and snare drum so it's a different orchestration in a way.

MR: I wanted to play a couple of little pieces of music here, and just see if you have any kind of comment.

[audio interlude]

We mentioned him before. That was Marcus Miller and Victor Wooten and Stanley Clarke. Do you have any reaction to that?

DF: I think they sound terrific. I mean as an electric bass player, Marcus is one of my all-time favorites. Stanley I actually prefer on acoustic bass. I love the way he sounds — or sounded. I haven't heard him recently. I think the guy is an unbelievable bass player. Victor, he's astounding technically. I don't have any Victor Wooten records, for whatever reason. But I think that's great. And you can hear, I don't know who's playing the solo, if that's Marcus or —

MR: I think it was Marcus and Victor. Actually I think Stanley was playing acoustic. He was just doing the —

DF: You can hear Marcus playing behind the beat. I mean he's totally laid back on his solo, against the feel. It feels good.

MR: Yeah. It's almost like an extreme bass — you know, like extreme sports, but with the bass.

DF: Yeah, yeah. The thing that scares me about Marcus, I did this jazz cruise — actually John Fedchock does it every year. And Marcus has been on it and his band's unbelievable and he plays a great slap bass solo that's very melodic. It's not just hey look what I can do. And he plays great melodies. And then he put the bass down and he picked up the bass clarinet and played "When I Fall in Love." And I was like now I really don't like you. I mean I hate when guys can do all that stuff. He plays guitar and keyboard.

MR: Yeah. He pretty much like made Miles records. Like get it all done and then, "okay Miles, come in and play a few notes."

DF: And it's very funny. There's a great track called "Funkin' for Jamaica" or "Jamaica Funk" it was a Tom Brown record. My friend Buddy Williams was playing drums on it. And it was a great bass line. And I knew that Marcus was on the record. Buddy said to me, "Marcus isn't playing bass on that, he's playing guitar." I was like, "really?" Oh God.

MR: Okay.

[audio interlude]

I really love this. How did you learn how to play that music?

DF: Let me tell you something. That record is one of the records of which I am most proud. And I played in Paquito D'Rivera's band I guess probably about five years. And I was recommended to Paquito by Claudio Roditi who is a wonderful trumpet player, Brazilian guy, who I guess heard that I had some kind of sense of this music. I always liked it. Like even in high school I remember I'd turn on the salsa station and go man that's cool. And the bass players totally function — like there's another example of functioning as the bass of the rhythm and harmony, and you have to maintain — there are some rules about playing Latin music to which you must adhere, which, us gringos do the best we can. Because I didn't grow up with it. But what happened was both Paquito and Claudio, who are very open and helpful, we'd be playing and I remember Paquito coming over and singing in my ear a cha-cha-cha bass line. A very traditional one. And I played and, "oh no, no, no, no, no, no." And then I'd get it. And so that was like on-the-spot training. And Claudio did the same thing with samba. He might sing a little rhythm or a little line that was traditional samba rhythm that I could incorporate. That helped a lot. In Paquito's

band we also had a drummer who was very strong with that stuff, and a pianist — I think that's Danilo Perez on that.

MR: I think so.

DF: So that became — I became a student with those guys. I don't even know if I could do that now. I was pretty good at it then and it's a different mindset. And now when I listen to a really great Latin jazz bass player like Andy Gonzalez and I hear him play, and I go there's an accent that he's got that I don't have. And a dear friend of mine made me a copy of a beautiful record. Talk about stealing stuff and making illegal copies — but he wanted me to hear this record and he was on it. And it was an Eddie Palmieri record. And he said, "listen to the bass player." And the bass player played a little behind. He played — you know in a bass line theoretically you'd be going [scats]. That's how I play it. He played [scats]. He had the six going on with the four and he was completely loose with it. And when you — I guess insert that into the machinery of the rest of the rhythm section it feels unbelievable. And I tried to do it. I played along with the record. I kind of got it but it's like speaking another language.

MR: Yes, and I think you almost have to have grown up with that kind of music. So it's not foreign. You're not starting in a foreign place, it's just a groove you understand.

DF: And a lot of it comes from language. It's interesting because I realize when I listen — on Paquito's band when I'd listen to the Cuban guys speaking, sometimes I go you know that sounds like congas. They were like fast and loud and exciting. [scats] It sounded like a Giovanni Hidalgo conga solo to me.

MR: What was that name you just said?

DF: Giovanni Hidalgo. He's great. He's Puerto Rican and great, great conga player. Maybe one of the greatest in the world. And also in Brazilian music you hear certain things in the language that are part of the music and vice versa. And some of it I think comes from the indigenous world — jungle sounds, tropical sounds, all of the drum stuff of course is African-based in Cuban music and in Brazilian music, well in all music really. But there is a connection to language for sure.

MR: Here's something totally different.

[audio interlude "Old Man Time" by Milt Hinton]

Do you have a Milt Hinton story?

DF: I only have one Milt Hinton story, because I didn't really know him. But one day I was entering the musicians union and I had my bass and I had an amplifier I think, at the same time. And it was like one of those days in New York where it was like 200 degrees and humid. And I went through the door of the union and I hit the cold air and I was like ahhh man. It just felt great to have the air conditioning finally descend upon me. And I hear this guy say, "hey man, what's the matter with you?" He said, "when I came up there

wasn't any air conditioning in this building." And I looked up and it was Milt. He had the hat and everything else. I go, "are you Milt Hinton?" "That's right." He was nice. I chatted with him very briefly. But I did know he's clearly a great bass player. There are a lot of great stories about him. And the other guy from that era who is unbelievable is George Duvivier. George played on zillions of records. I knew him a little bit. I subbed for him a couple of times back in you know, 1982. And there's another bass player that a lot of people don't know about named Jerry Bruno. Jerry is 90 something, maybe 95 years old. When I tell you this guy knows everything. He knows everything. Every song. He's unstumpable. Every alternate chord. A wonderful musician.

MR: Is he a New Jersey person?

DF: He lives in New Jersey.

MR: Yeah, a lot of good musicians. Bucky [Pizzarelli].

DF: Bucky's there. He and Bucky go back forever. Yeah.

MR: Wow. Do you ever — sometimes I'm fascinated about living in another era. And I wonder if you ever have done that? For musical reasons?

DF: Yeah. Every now and then I wish I had been maybe a generation and a half or two generations before. I think before the music business went digital and there were some players that I would have loved to have the opportunity to work with. So yeah, once in a while. I suppose everybody does. And of course business-wise all the guys a generation or two older than me go, "oh yeah, you should have been in New York in the 1960's through '79." Because there were more jobs than there were players.

MR: They were doing three dates a day.

DF: They were busy.

MR: But you know it looks like you're busy to me. From what I've read about you. Is that a fair statement?

DF: I would say generally I am, but our business is affected by the economy. And usually the first thing to go — nobody's going to eliminate the flow of oil and gas and electricity. But they can do without entertainment if they have to. So I would say now there seem to be fewer and fewer recording sessions, although I've been producing records for people and I do my best to do it all with live musicians. And the guys really — we always have a good time. They go, "oh man, this is like the old days. It's actually a big band." Or, "man, I remember when we used to do this twice a week." And I think for that reason, because they are live players I think the records sound really good.

MR: Does anything — what makes you angry?

DF: Well you mean in music?

MR: I guess, but in general. What really pushes your buttons?

DF: Well to be honest, several things push my buttons. Unfairness troubles me. Racism disgusts me. In fact my mother once when I was young said something very funny and I remind her it's not funny it's true and humorous. And I reminded her of this not too long ago. At some point when I was, I don't know how old I was, there was something racially charged on the news. And she said, "you know it's really stupid to dislike somebody for what they look like or what they weigh and to dismiss an entire group of people like that is stupid, when there are plenty of really good reasons to hate people on an individual basis." You know? She's right. Jerks come in all sizes, shapes and colors. So that bothers me, and I don't like people who impose their religious beliefs on others. I find that highly offensive and particularly offensive when they are people who are elected to work for us in government. That troubles me. Without getting into it, I think you know what I mean, and I have no problem with people believing whatever they choose to believe, but you can't throw that at others and expect them to think the way you do, because we're all Americans. That's ridiculous.

MR: Well said. Well we're just about an hour here. Yeah. So I really enjoyed talking to you.

DF: Likewise.

MR: And maybe down the road we'll do Part II.

DF: I would love to.

MR: And did you drive all the way up here from New York today?

DF: I live in New City, New York, which is 30 or so miles north of the city.

MR: Yeah. It's still a hike.

DF: Yeah, it was about three and a half.

MR: But you got to listen to some Sinatra.

DF: I listened to Sinatra, and I got my headphones so I talked to a few friends to pass the time. I'm used to traveling. For a while I taught at Bennington College so I used to do it in a day. I would drive up in the morning through Albany and then over into Vermont, teach, and then usually I would drive back home afterwards.

MR: That's a long day.

DF: Yeah. It was a long day. And I have some good stories about that too.

MR: Well good luck. I know you're working with a good crew tonight. And I have a gig myself but I hope to get there for the end of it.

DF: Okay great. Is that a nice place? I've never played there.

MR: It's a little performance space. It's narrow, but it's hip.

DF: So it's like a concert?

MR: Yes, it's like a little concert. People sit. And it's a series they got a grant for it. And so it'll be nice.

DF: That's great. That's terrific.

MR: And there's a little coffee shop next door and a bar across the street.

DF: Well, I'll be at the coffee shop.

MR: Yeah. Thanks a lot.

DF: Thank you.